likely names. The journalist suggested mine. ‘Ramachandra Guha has been critical of Indira Gandhi and the Emergency,’ responded Natwar Singh; ‘we

can’t have him.’ His lunch companion then offered the name of the distinguished Kolkata historian and political theorist, Partha Chatterjee.

‘I don’t know Chatterjee’s views on Indiraji, but he

has been critical of Panditji [Jawaharlal Nehru],’ said Mr Singh; ‘so we can’t have him either.’ *

II

The Nehru Memorial Museum and Library is located in the grounds of Teen Murti House which, in colonial times, used to be the home of the commander-in-chief of the British Indian Army. It was the second grandest residence in New Delhi, smaller only than the viceroy’s palace on Raisina Hill. When, in September 1946, Jawaharlal Nehru joined an interim government in the last year of colonial rule, he was assigned a decent-sized bungalow on York Road. After he became prime minister of India in August 1947, he stayed on in it. It was only in the middle of 1948 that he moved into Teen Murti House.

Cynics said at the time that Nehru had his eyes on the commander-in-chief’s house all along, but so long as Mahatma Gandhi was alive he did not dare live in it. To be fair, Nehru’s own needs were modest (if not quite as modest as the Mahatma’s); he probably felt that his new home was better suited to the parties and official receptions that the prime minister of a large and sovereign nation would have to host. At any rate, when Nehru died, in May 1964, his daughter Indira Gandhi was determined that her father would be the first and last Indian occupant of Teen Murti House. Shortly after the mourning period was over, it was announced that Nehru’s official residence would become a memorial to him.

There was a precedent, of sorts—in the shape of a house half a mile to the east, which had once belonged to the millionaire Ghanshyamdas Birla.